COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT PROGRAMME ON

"MUTUAL FUND SIP AWARENESS AND ENROLLMENT GUIDANCE CAMPS".

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BACHELOR'S IN FINANCIAL MARKETS
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UNDER THE GUIDANCE OF:
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Certificate

I hereby certify that Mr. Harsh Ramesh Jadhav, student of Prahladrai Dalmia Lions College pursuing, Bachelors in Financial Markets has Completed a project titled "MUTUAL FUND SIP AWARENESS AND ENROLLMENT GUIDANCE CAMPS" in the area of Financial Markets specialization for the academic year 2026-2027. To the best of my knowledge the work of the student is original and the information included in the project is correct.

Internal guideHead of the DepartmentPrincipal

DECLARATION

I, Mr. Harsh Ramesh Jadhav student of Prahladrai Dalmia Lions of Commerce and Economics, hereby declare that I have completed project entitled "MUTUAL FUND SIP AWARENESS AND ENROLLMENT GUIDANCE CAMPS " during the academic year 2026-2027.

The report work is original and the information/data included in the report is the emerging from the primary and/secondary data gathered and analysed as part of this project.

Due credit is extended on the work of Literature/Secondary Survey by endorsing it in the Bibliography as per prescribed format.

Signature of the Student with date

Name of Student: Harsh Ramesh Jadhav

Acknowledgement

To list who all helped me is difficult because they are so numerous and the depth is so enormous.

I would like to acknowledge the following as being an idealistic channel and fresh dimension and completion of project.

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Abstract

This project examines awareness and enrollment behaviour around Mutual Fund Systematic Investment Plans (SIPs) among the community of Prahladrai Dalmia Lions College, Malad West, through a field visit conducted using structured, interview-based data collection. Six respondents — comprising a finance student, a non-finance student, and four individuals including a business owner — were interviewed using a common ten-point questionnaire covering awareness of mutual funds and SIPs, current investment habits, risk appetite, and reasons for non-investment, followed by a short advisory briefing on the merits of SIP investing.

The field visit revealed that most respondents held only a surface-level understanding of mutual funds, frequently confusing them with fixed deposits or insurance products, and were largely unaware that SIP returns are market-linked rather than guaranteed. Awareness and investment behaviour varied by exposure: finance students and individuals with retirement planning experience demonstrated stronger understanding, while first-time investors cited fear of loss and lack of guidance, rather than unwillingness, as the primary barriers to entry. Encouragingly, every respondent expressed interest in learning more about SIPs after the brief advisory session, indicating a genuine appetite for financial literacy when delivered in accessible, jargon-free language.

The study concludes that the core gap limiting mutual fund adoption within the college community is not investor reluctance but insufficient prior exposure and simplified guidance. It recommends institutionalising periodic, advisor-led SIP awareness and enrollment camps, supported by simple explainer material and structured follow-up, to convert initial interest into sustained investment behaviour and build lasting financial literacy across students and staff alike.

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Mutual Fund SIP Awareness and Enrollment Guidance Camps

Chapter 1: Introduction

1.1 Introduction and Background

History of Mutual Funds in India

A strong financial market with broad participation is essential for a developed economy. With this broad objective, India's first mutual fund, the Unit Trust of India (UTI), was established in 1963 at the initiative of the Government of India and the Reserve Bank of India, with a view to encouraging saving and investment and participation in the income, profits and gains accruing to the Corporation from the acquisition, holding, management and disposal of securities.

In the last few years the mutual fund industry has grown significantly. The history of mutual funds in India can be broadly divided into five distinct phases, described below.

First Phase (1964–1987)

The mutual fund industry in India started with the formation of UTI in 1963 by an Act of Parliament, and it functioned under the regulatory and administrative control of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI). In 1978, UTI was de-linked from the RBI and the Industrial Development Bank of India (IDBI) took over the regulatory and administrative control. Unit Scheme 1964 (US '64) was the first scheme launched by UTI. At the end of 1988, UTI had ₹6,700 crore of Assets Under Management (AUM).

Second Phase (1987–1993): Entry of Public Sector Mutual Funds

The year 1987 marked the entry of public sector mutual funds set up by public sector banks, the Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC) and the General Insurance Corporation of India (GIC). SBI Mutual Fund was the first 'non-UTI' mutual fund, established in June 1987, followed by Canbank Mutual Fund (December 1987), Punjab National Bank Mutual Fund (August 1989), Indian

Bank Mutual Fund (November 1989), Bank of India (June 1990) and Bank of Baroda Mutual Fund (October 1992).

LIC established its mutual fund in June 1989, while GIC set up its mutual fund in December 1990. At the end of 1993, the mutual fund industry had assets under management of ₹47,004 crore.

Third Phase (1993–2003): Entry of Private Sector Mutual Funds

The Indian securities market gained greater importance with the establishment of SEBI in April 1992 to protect the interests of investors in the securities market and to promote the development of, and regulate, the securities market.

In 1993, the first set of SEBI Mutual Fund Regulations came into being for all mutual funds except UTI. The erstwhile Kothari Pioneer (now merged with Franklin Templeton Mutual Fund) was the first private sector mutual fund, registered in July 1993. With the entry of private sector funds in 1993, a new era began in the Indian mutual fund industry, giving Indian investors a wider choice of products. The initial SEBI regulations were revised and replaced in 1996 with a comprehensive set of regulations, the SEBI (Mutual Fund) Regulations, 1996, which are currently applicable.

The number of mutual funds increased over the years, with many foreign sponsors setting up mutual funds in India, and the industry witnessed several mergers and acquisitions during this phase. As at the end of January 2003, there were 33 mutual funds with total AUM of ₹1,21,805 crore, out of which UTI alone had AUM of ₹44,541 crore.

Fourth Phase (February 2003 – April 2014)

In February 2003, following the repeal of the Unit Trust of India Act 1963, UTI was bifurcated into two separate entities: the Specified Undertaking of the Unit Trust of India (SUUTI) and UTI Mutual Fund, which functions under the SEBI Mutual Fund Regulations. With the bifurcation of the erstwhile UTI and several

mergers among private sector funds, the industry entered its fourth phase of consolidation.

Following the global meltdown of 2009, securities markets all over the world tanked, and India was no exception. Most investors who had entered the capital market at its peak lost money, and their faith in mutual fund products was shaken greatly. The abolition of entry load by SEBI, coupled with the after-effects of the global financial crisis, deepened the adverse impact on the industry, which struggled to recover and remodel itself for over two years in an attempt to maintain its economic viability. This is evident from the sluggish growth in industry AUM between 2010 and 2013.

Fifth (Current) Phase: Since May 2014

Taking cognisance of the lack of penetration of mutual funds, especially in tier II and tier III cities, and the need for greater alignment of the interests of various stakeholders, SEBI introduced several progressive measures in September 2012 to "re-energize" the Indian mutual fund industry and increase penetration. In due course, the measures succeeded in reversing the negative trend that had set in after the global meltdown, and the position improved significantly after the new Government was formed at the Centre.

Since May 2014, the industry has witnessed steady inflows and an increase in AUM as well as in the number of investor folios (accounts). The industry's AUM crossed the milestone of ₹10 trillion (₹10 lakh crore) for the first time on 31 May 2014. In a short span of about three years the AUM more than doubled and crossed ₹20 trillion for the first time in August 2017. It crossed ₹30 trillion for the first time in November 2020.

- The overall size of the Indian mutual fund industry has grown from ₹15.18 trillion on 31 July 2016 to ₹85.76 trillion on 31 July 2026, about a six-fold increase in ten years.

- The industry's AUM has grown from ₹35.32 trillion on 31 July 2021 to ₹85.76 trillion on 31 July 2026, about a three-fold increase in five years.
- The number of investor folios has gone up from 10.55 crore on 31 July 2021 to 28.09 crore on 31 July 2026, more than a two-and-a-half-fold increase in five years.
- On average, 29.23 lakh new folios have been added every month over the last five years since July 2021.

Mutual fund distributors have been providing the much-needed last-mile connect with investors, particularly in smaller towns. This is not limited to enabling investors to invest in appropriate schemes, but also extends to helping investors stay on course through bouts of market volatility and thus experience the benefit of investing in mutual funds.

What are Mutual Funds?

Mutual funds (MFs) are investment vehicles that pool money from multiple investors and invest it in a diversified portfolio of different asset classes, such as:

- Equities (stocks)
- Debt instruments (bonds, debentures)
- Money market instruments and/or other securities

Managed by an Asset Management Company (AMC), mutual funds offer investors the benefits of professional fund management, diversification, and investment within a regulated structure. Technically, investors do not invest in a mutual fund itself; it is a medium which allows them to invest in securities that may otherwise be difficult to invest in directly.

Understanding This with an Example

Suppose you want to invest in the top 50 companies listed on the NSE (National Stock Exchange of India), such as Reliance, TCS, Infosys and HDFC Bank. Instead of buying shares in 50 stocks individually, you can simply pick a Nifty

50 Index Fund, such as the Groww Nifty 50 Index Fund. This fund invests your money in all the companies that make up the Nifty 50 index, in the same proportion as the index itself. By investing in this fund, you get exposure to the performance of the entire Nifty 50 index without having to buy each stock.

History of Mutual Funds in India: Summary Timeline

- **1964–1987 (Establishment):** UTI is set up by an Act of Parliament and the Reserve Bank of India, launching its famous Unit Scheme 1964 (US-64).
- **1987–1993 (Public Sector Entry):** Public sector banks and institutions (like SBI Mutual Fund and LIC) break UTI's monopoly.
- **1993–2003 (Private Sector and SEBI):** Private and foreign asset management companies enter following market liberalisation and the formation of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) regulations.
- **2003–2014 (Consolidation and Reforms):** UTI is bifurcated into separate entities, and SEBI abolishes entry loads to increase transparency.
- **2014–Present (Digital Growth):** Outreach campaigns and online investing platforms drive massive retail participation through Systematic Investment Plans (SIPs).

What is a SIP? How SIPs Work

A SIP, or Systematic Investment Plan, is a process of investing a fixed amount of money in mutual funds or stocks on a daily, weekly, monthly or quarterly basis. The amount is automatically deducted from the investor's bank account, and mutual fund units are allocated based on the fund's Net Asset Value (NAV) on the investment date. This allows investors to build wealth over time.

A SIP offers a flexible approach, where one can choose how much to invest regularly. It is a "long-term investment strategy" in which one can start investing with as little as ₹100.

A Systematic Investment Plan works through a simple 3-step process. To start investing in a SIP, the investor needs to decide on three important parameters:

- **Amount:** How much you want to invest (₹500, ₹1,000, ₹5,000 or more).
- **Frequency:** Monthly (most common), weekly, or quarterly.
- **Scheme:** The mutual fund in which your money will be invested.

For those who opt for a stock SIP, the amount is invested in the selected stock. The entire investment process and returns depend solely on what one selects in this step. Once the parameters are decided, the SIP can be set up via a third-party investment platform like Groww, a financial advisor, or directly through the AMC.

Importance of SIP in Wealth Creation

The following excerpt, "SIP Helps in Building Wealth: Myth or Reality?" by Prasun Singh (24 September 2025), explains the role of SIPs in wealth creation.

A plant needs regular and steady watering to thrive, just as a Systematic Investment Plan requires disciplined, fixed investments at regular intervals into a mutual fund. This consistent approach can help investors navigate market ups and downs, just like a well-nourished plant withstands changing weather. Investing too much at once can be risky, while irregular investing may stunt progress. SIPs encourage financial discipline over time, and over the years this steady habit may contribute to long-term wealth creation.

economic shifts, global crises, or breaking news. Emotional decisions often lead to poor outcomes, like buying high or selling low.

l1.2 Objectives

The main objectives of mutual fund awareness programmes are to demystify investment concepts, promote financial literacy, explain risk-return dynamics, encourage disciplined saving through tools like SIPs, and guide investors toward goal-based financial planning.

1. Demystifying Investment Concepts

- **Explain money pooling:** Show how small amounts combine into a large corpus.
- **Define NAV:** Teach what Net Asset Value means for a buyer.
- **Highlight management:** Introduce the role of professional fund managers.

2. Promoting Financial Literacy

- **Expand reach:** Target tier-2 and tier-3 cities with regional outreach.
- **Simplify jargon:** Translate complex terms into simple local languages.
- **Build trust:** Share official guidelines from market regulators like SEBI.

3. Understanding Risk and Return

- **Clarify risk:** Teach that market-linked products carry inherent risks.
- **Match profiles:** Help users align risk tolerance with fund types.
- **Manage expectations:** Discourage panic selling during market drops.

4. Encouraging Disciplined Investing

- **Promote SIPs:** Highlight Systematic Investment Plans for regular saving.
- **Teach consistency:** Emphasise the power of compounding over time.
- **Prevent timing:** Discourage efforts to time the unpredictable market.

5. Guiding Goal-Based Planning

- **Map goals:** Link investments to life tarets like retirement or education.
- **Set horizons:** Teach how time frames dictate fund selection.

- **Review portfolios:** Encourage periodic checks and rebalancing.

1.3 Scope

The scope of mutual fund awareness encompasses educating the public on wealth creation, expanding financial literacy in tier-2/3 cities and rural areas, promoting Systematic Investment Plans (SIPs), and converting traditional savers into market investors while demystifying market risks.

Target Demographics and Expansion

- **Tier-2, Tier-3 and Rural Markets:** Vast untapped potential exists outside metro cities as regional language campaigns and digital access scale up.
- **Young Professionals and Students:** Early integration of financial concepts helps build long-term investing habits through compounding.
- **Traditional Savers:** Shifting focus from physical gold and fixed deposits to financial assets.

Core Areas of Education

- **SIP Mechanics:** Teaching regular, disciplined investing starting with small amounts.
- **Risk vs. Return:** Clear communication regarding market volatility and realistic expectations.
- **Goal-Based Planning:** Aligning investments with life milestones like retirement, education and housing.

Industry and Regulatory Outreach

- **Investor Awareness Programmes (IAPs):** Regular physical and virtual workshops conducted across India, backed by bodies like the Association of Mutual Funds in India (AMFI).
- **Digital Channels:** Leveraging fintech apps, social media and educational portals to simplify financial jargon.

Chapter 2: Literature Review

This chapter reviews existing studies and industry sources on mutual funds, Systematic Investment Plans (SIPs), investor behaviour and financial-literacy initiatives. It builds on the history and growth of the Indian mutual fund industry described in Chapter 1 and focuses on three questions: how SIPs compare with other modes of investing, how far awareness and financial literacy shape investment decisions, and how effective awareness programmes have been in reaching different groups of investors.

2.1 SIPs, Investor Behaviour and Market Trends

- **Challa, S. R. (2025) —** Compared SIP and lump-sum investing on risk management and long-term wealth building. The study found that the fixed, regular investing discipline of a SIP averages the purchase cost and lowers exposure to volatility, compared with lump-sum investing that depends on market timing, and suggested that a combination of both often suits investors best.
- **Sharma, K., & Joshi, P. (2023) —** Studied awareness of investing through SIPs among residents of North Ahmedabad (Sachetas, 2(3), 31–42). The study examined the level of awareness, financial objectives and factors influencing SIP investment, and noted that investors increasingly regard SIPs as a means of reaching long-term financial goals and creating wealth.
- **Kulkarni, Iyengar & Afaque (2023), as cited in an IJCRT review (2025) —** Explored how investors become aware of and decide on mutual funds and SIPs. Awareness was found to be growing, but decisions were often made on limited information, pointing to a need for more targeted investor education.
- **Franklin Templeton, India Annual Outlook 2026 (cited December 2025) —** Reported that industry assets grew 21% in the year to November 2025 against an 11% rise in the Nifty 50. Monthly SIP inflows touched a

record ₹29,529 crore in October 2025, and total SIP flows for 2025 reached ₹3.03 lakh crore, up from ₹2.47 lakh crore a year earlier. The report links this partly to growing retail awareness and financial literacy.

- **Zenodo Study on Evolving Investment Preferences of Students (2026)** — A secondary-data study drawing on scholarly articles and SEBI, AMFI and RBI publications. It found that mutual funds remain the most preferred option among Indian students because of their relative safety, liquidity and low capital requirement, supported by the popularity of SIPs, while stock investing is gaining ground among commerce and finance students through online platforms.

2.2 Awareness and Financial Literacy

- **NCFE Financial Literacy and Inclusion Survey (2019) —** The national survey by the National Centre for Financial Education found that 27.18% of respondents met the minimum threshold in each component of financial literacy, up from 20% in 2013. The western, north-eastern, northern and southern zones scored above the national average of 27%.
- **Molla, S. A., & Das, S. (2024) —** Analysed the NCFE-FLIS 2019 report (International Journal of Commerce and Management Research, 10(6), 63–68). Only about 27% of individuals were found to be financially literate, with marked variation by socio-economic and demographic factors. Goa ranked highest and Chhattisgarh lowest among the states, and western India scored higher than other regions.
- **Sangolgi, R., & Kulkarni, V. (2026) —** Studied mutual fund awareness among students of Visvesvaraya Technological University through a questionnaire administered to 62 undergraduate and postgraduate students. Most had basic awareness, but only a limited share understood investment procedures, risk assessment, NAV and SIP mechanics. Social media, the

internet, family and peers were the main sources of awareness, and the study called for structured financial education.

- **Nithya, Ragini & Preetha (2024), as cited in an IJCRT review (2025)** — Examined the role of financial literacy in investment planning among college students. Financial literacy significantly influenced students' ability to make informed investment decisions, and the authors suggested including financial education in college curricula.
- **Rural–Urban Inequality in Mutual Fund Participation, AMFI Data Study (2026) —** Analysed AMFI data for 2019–2025 and found that, although industry AUM has crossed ₹77 lakh crore, growth remains concentrated in the top 30 (T30) urban centres. Low product knowledge, poor understanding of fund structure and confusion about how SIPs work are repeatedly cited as the main barriers for rural investors.

2.3 Awareness Programmes and Initiatives

- **AMFI, "Mutual Funds Sahi Hai" Campaign (2017) —** AMFI, guided by SEBI, launched a nationwide multimedia investor-awareness campaign financed through a mandatory investor-education pool of 2 basis points. It used TV, radio, print and digital media in several languages to encourage households to move savings from physical assets to mutual funds, and remains a foundation for later awareness initiatives.
- **Verma (2022) —** Evaluated the RBI's Financial Literacy Week campaign and found good visibility and media reach in urban areas but weaker outreach in rural areas, which limits how inclusive such campaigns are. This is a gap that localised, community-level sessions can help to fill.
- **"From Awareness to Action" (Inspira Journals) —** Assessed the financial literacy programmes run by SEBI, AMFI, RBI and NCFE. Awareness improved at first, but retention of knowledge fell over time and

practical application stayed low, indicating that repeated, hands-on learning works better than a single session.

- **SEBI Investor Awareness Programmes framework —** SEBI conducts investor awareness through structured formats such as the Securities Market Trainers (SMARTs) programme, Regional Investor Seminars for Awareness (RISA) and sessions led by Investor Associations, providing an institutional template for awareness activity.
- **SEBI, "Bharat Kaa Share Bazaar" Pavilion Initiative (2023) —** SEBI, together with the exchanges (BSE, NSE, MCX, NCDEX) and depositories and associations (CDSL, NSDL, AMFI), used talk shows, skits and interactive exhibits at public fairs to spread investor awareness, showing that interactive formats are an accepted, regulator-endorsed approach.
- **SEBI Action on Unregistered "Finfluencers" (2024–2025) —** SEBI restricted unregistered online educators from giving real-time stock tips disguised as education, including action against a YouTuber for unregistered investment advisory services. This highlights the importance of credible, regulator-backed awareness programmes as an alternative to unverified social-media advice.

Research Gap

The literature shows that SIPs are widely regarded as a suitable route to long-term wealth creation and that industry assets, SIP flows and investor folios have grown strongly, as described in Chapter 1, where assets under management rose from ₹15.18 trillion in July 2016 to ₹85.76 trillion in July 2026. At the same time, several studies report uneven awareness across regions and income groups, limited depth of understanding even among students, and a decline in knowledge retention after one-off programmes. Few studies examine, through direct interaction, why individuals with different occupations and financial backgrounds do or do not invest in mutual funds and SIPs.

Chapter 3: Methodology

3.1 Research Approach

This is a small-scale qualitative study based on face-to-face interviews. It looks at how well people know mutual funds and Systematic Investment Plans (SIPs), what they currently do with their savings and what holds them back, and it uses each meeting to explain the basics of disciplined, long-term investing, as set out in the objectives in Chapter 1.

3.2 Aim of the Study

The study was designed to:

- Find out what respondents know about mutual funds, SIPs and other saving options, how they currently save or invest, what they think about risk and what worries them.
- Explain mutual funds and SIPs in simple terms and show why regular, long-term investing matters.
- Help respondents think about their goals and take informed investment decisions.

3.3 Place of Study and Respondent Groups

The interviews were held at Prahladrai Dalmia Lions College of Commerce & Economics, Malad (West), Mumbai, with two kinds of respondents:

- College students
- Adults from other occupations and financial backgrounds

Speaking to both groups made it possible to compare people of different ages, incomes and exposure to money matters, because the awareness gaps described in Chapter 1 differ from one group to another.

3.4 Selection of Respondents

- **Method:** Purposive (judgemental) sampling, in which people from the two groups who agreed to be interviewed were chosen.

- **Number of respondents:** 6, made up of 4 adults and 2 students.

3.5 Sources of Data

Primary data was collected through personal interviews. Ten short, simple questions were prepared beforehand and asked to every respondent in the same order, and the answers were noted down. The questions dealt with:

- Awareness of mutual funds and SIPs
- Present saving and investing habits and the options respondents prefer
- Understanding of risk and belief about guaranteed returns
- Reasons for not investing in mutual funds, the amount that could be invested, financial goals and interest in awareness sessions

Secondary data was collected from books, journals, AMFI and SEBI publications and websites, and articles. This material supports the background in Chapter 1 and the literature review in Chapter 2.

3.6 Educational Briefing

At the end of each interview the respondent was given a short explanation of:

- Why mutual funds are useful: professional management, spreading of risk, easy withdrawal, a low starting amount (a SIP can begin at ₹100) and regulation by SEBI
- Investing with discipline: beginning early, investing a fixed amount regularly through a SIP, staying invested for many years and not trying to guess market movements
- Planning around goals: choosing funds that suit one's comfort with risk and one's target, and checking the investment from time to time

This explanation was meant only to create awareness and was not personal financial advice.

3.7 Method of Analysis

The answers were compared across the two groups and common patterns were noted. The findings are presented as short interview profiles, followed by a summary of observations, in Chapter 4.

3.8 Constraints of the Study

- Only six people were interviewed, all connected with one college, so the findings cannot be applied to everyone.
- The answers depend on what respondents were willing to share and how well they understood the questions.
- The study captures views at a single point in time.
- Investments in mutual funds are subject to market risk.

Chapter 4: Description of the community interactions, Observations and Analysis

For the purpose of this study, an interview-based method was adopted to gather first-hand, qualitative insights into the investment behaviour and awareness levels of the college community. Six respondents were selected from two categories, students and individuals from other occupational backgrounds, so as to capture a range of ages, income levels and financial exposure. Each interview was structured around a common set of core questions, beginning with whether the respondent currently invests their savings at all and, if so, through which instruments. Respondents were asked whether they lean towards traditional saving methods or market-linked options such as mutual funds, how comfortable they were with market fluctuations, and whether they preferred stable, low-risk instruments or were open to greater risk in pursuit of better returns. They were also asked about their financial goals and whether they believed SIPs guarantee fixed returns, which allowed the interviewers to gauge their understanding of risk, compounding and long-term wealth creation. For respondents with limited or no engagement with mutual funds, follow-up questions explored the reasons, whether fear of loss, lack of knowledge, complexity of products, existing commitments or the absence of guidance. After each interview, the respondent was briefed on the basics of mutual funds and SIPs, as described in Chapter 1. This approach made it possible to understand not only what respondents knew, but why the gaps existed, and it formed the basis for the recommendations in Chapter 5.

The questions asked are as follows:

1. Have you heard about mutual funds?
2. Do you know what a SIP is?
3. Are you saving or investing any money right now?

4. Which option do you like most for your savings: bank savings, fixed deposit, gold, shares or mutual funds?
5. Do you think the value of market investments can fall as well as rise?
6. What stops you from investing in mutual funds?
7. What monthly amount could you set aside for a SIP?
8. What is your main purpose for saving or investing?
9. Do you believe a SIP guarantees returns
10. Would you attend a short session to learn more about mutual funds and SIPs?

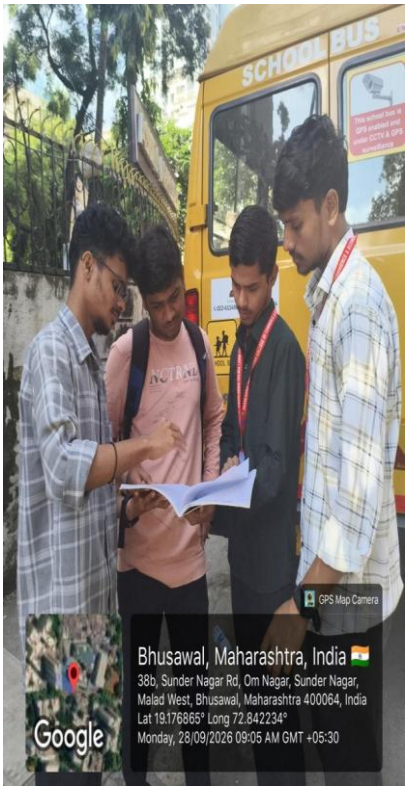
- **A short conversation with a resident near Prahladrai Dalmia Lions College, Malad West.**



Field visit: team members go through the questionnaire with a resident near Prahladrai Dalmia Lions College, Malad West.

The finance student interviewed demonstrated a clear understanding of mutual funds and SIPs, correctly identifying them as pooled, professionally managed investments and a disciplined way to invest fixed amounts periodically. The respondent confirmed already investing through SIPs, showing a preference for mutual funds over traditional options like fixed deposits due to better long-term growth potential. They displayed a strong grasp of investment risk, acknowledging that returns are market-linked and not guaranteed, correctly stating that SIPs do not offer assured returns. The student indicated comfort starting a SIP with a modest monthly amount of around ₹500–₹2,000, with the primary goal of long-term wealth creation for future needs such as education or an emergency fund. They also expressed strong interest in attending future awareness camps to further enhance their financial knowledge.

- **A quick chat with a few residents outside the college campus, Malad West.**



Field visit: team members review responses together outside the college campus, Malad West.

The SY student interviewed showed limited awareness of mutual funds and SIPs, having only vaguely heard the terms without understanding their actual meaning or functioning. The respondent confirmed having no investment experience, with savings currently kept only in a bank account, and no preferred investment avenue. Their understanding of investment risk was minimal, reflecting a lack of exposure to how market-linked returns operate. The primary reason cited for not investing was a lack of knowledge and awareness, coupled with apprehension about losing money due to limited understanding of associated risks. If starting a SIP, the student expressed comfort with a small monthly amount of around ₹100–₹500, given constrained disposable income as a student. No clear financial goal was identified, aside from a general intention to save for the future or emergencies. Notably, the student incorrectly believed that SIPs offer fixed or guaranteed returns, similar to a recurring deposit, indicating a misconcepabout.

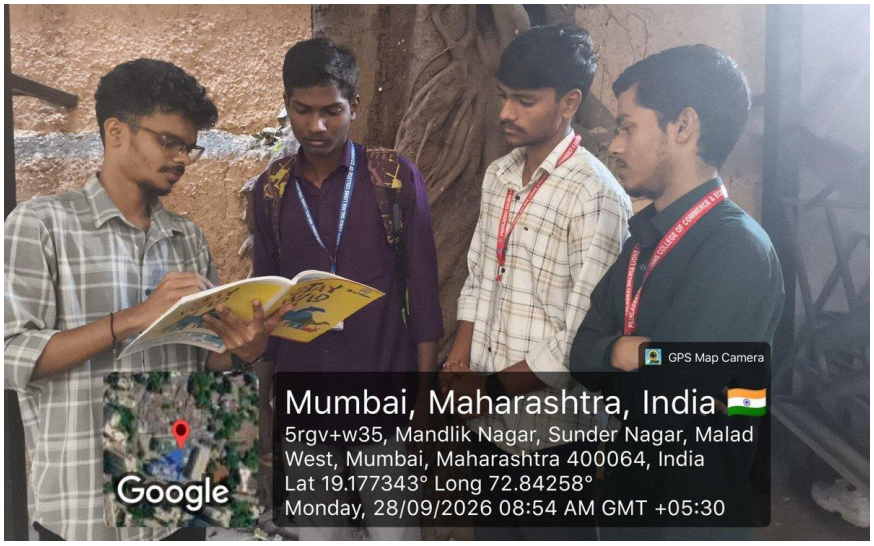
- **A brief meet-up with a resident near Sunder Nagar, Malad West.**



Field visit: team members go through the interview notes with a respondent near Sunder Nagar, Malad West.

The individual interviewed admitted to having very little understanding of mutual funds, stating that while they had heard the term before, they could not explain how it actually works. They were equally unfamiliar with the concept of a Systematic Investment Plan (SIP) and had never invested in any financial instrument, citing a general lack of financial literacy as a major barrier. Any savings they had were simply kept in a bank account, with no active investment avenue being used. Their understanding of investment risk was very poor, as they did not grasp how market-linked returns could fluctuate. When asked why they hadn't invested in mutual funds, they candidly expressed fear — a concern about losing their hard-earned money — combined with not knowing enough about how such investments function to feel confident taking the step. If persuaded to start, they indicated they would only be comfortable with a very small monthly amount, given their cautious mindset and limited financial knowledge. They did not have a clearly defined financial goal, mentioning only a genersecurity or safety.

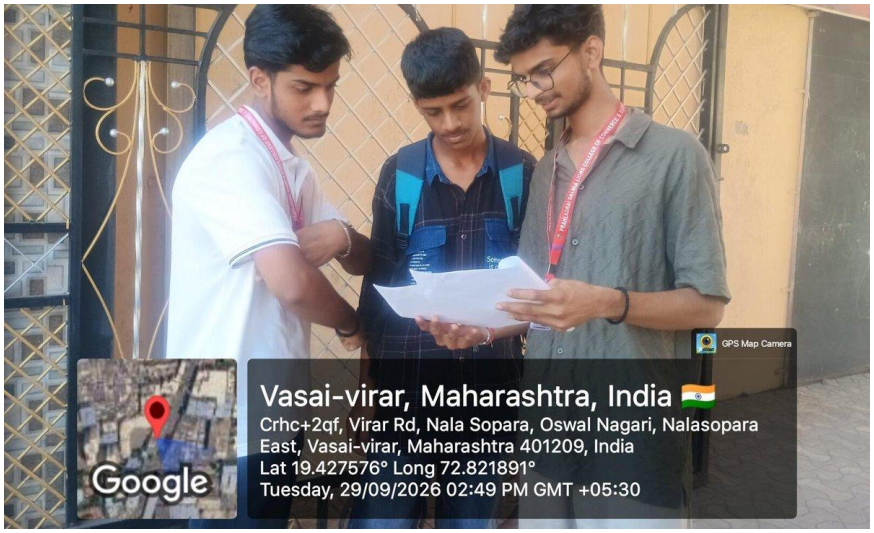
- **A short meet-up near Mandlik Nagar, Malad West.**



Field visit: team members discuss the questionnaire near Mandlik Nagar, Malad West.

The individual interviewed displayed a reasonably good understanding of mutual funds, recognizing them as pooled investment vehicles, largely due to prior exposure through retirement-focused financial planning. They were also familiar with the concept of a Systematic Investment Plan (SIP), though their own investment experience has been centered around retirement funds rather than SIPs in equity or hybrid mutual funds. The respondent confirmed currently investing in retirement-oriented instruments, reflecting a preference for long-term, goal-based investment avenues over short-term or speculative options. Their understanding of investment risk was moderate to good, shaped by years of exposure to retirement planning, though possibly more cautious given the priority placed on capital protection for retirement needs. When it came to mutual funds specifically, their limited engagement stemmed from having already committed their long-term savings to retirement funds, leaving little additional surplus for other mutual fund investments. If considering a SIP, they indicated a willingness to start with a moderate monthly amount, reflecting a stable financial position typical of someone with established retirement planning. Their primary financial goal centered around retirement security and ensuring a stable post-retirement income, rather than short-term wealth creation.

- **A brief conversation with a resident in Nalasopara East.**



Field visit: team members conduct an interview near a respondent's residence in Nalasopara East.

The business owner interviewed showed a strong understanding of mutual funds, having already invested in them, and was well aware of the concept of a Systematic Investment Plan (SIP) as well. However, despite this awareness, they do not currently invest through SIPs, explaining that the fixed, recurring nature of SIP contributions does not suit their financial situation, as they need to retain liquidity and cash flow flexibility to manage and reinvest in their business. Their preferred investment avenue leans toward mutual funds invested via lump sum, allowing them to deploy funds only when surplus cash is available rather than committing to a fixed monthly outflow. The respondent demonstrated a solid understanding of investment risk, being well aware that market-linked returns can fluctuate and are not guaranteed. When asked why they avoid SIPs specifically, they cited business cash flow requirements as the main reason, rather than any lack of knowledge or fear of risk. If circumstances allowed, they indicated they would be open to starting a SIP with a reasonably substantial monthly amount, reflecting their financial capacity as a business owner. Their primary financial goal for investing was long-term wealth creation and portfolio diversification, alongside using surplus business profits productively rather than letting them remain idle. They clearly understood that SIPs, like mutual funds in general.

- **A quick meet-up with residents in Nalasopara East.**



Field visit: team members note down responses during an interview in Nalasopara East.

The individual interviewed had a basic, surface-level awareness of mutual funds, having heard of the term through general conversations or media, but lacked a clear understanding of how they actually function. Similarly, they had heard of Systematic Investment Plans (SIPs) but could not elaborate much beyond recognizing the term. Despite this general awareness of investments, the respondent confirmed they had never actually invested in any financial instrument, with their savings simply sitting idle in a bank account. Consequently, they did not have any preferred investment avenue, as they had not yet taken the step of exploring or committing to one. Their understanding of investment risk was fairly limited, reflecting the fact that their knowledge remained largely theoretical rather than practical. When asked why they hadn't invested despite being aware of such options, they pointed to a combination of factors — not fully understanding how to get started, uncertainty about which option would suit them, and a general hesitation to take the first step. If they were to begin, they suggested they would prefer starting with a small, manageable monthly amount to ease into investing without much pressure. Their primary financial goal was somewhat general, centered around saving for the future.

Summary of Observations

The six interviews, considered together, point to the following observations:

- **Investment status:** Three respondents (the finance student, the individual invested in retirement funds and the business owner) currently invest. The other three, including the SY student, keep their savings only in a bank account.
- **Awareness gap:** Three respondents had only surface-level or very limited understanding of mutual funds and SIPs, even though they had heard the terms.
- **Risk and return:** Two respondents wrongly believed that SIPs give fixed or guaranteed returns and one was unsure. The other three correctly understood that SIP returns are market-linked. This confirms the need to explain risk and return clearly, as set out in the objectives in Chapter 1.
- **Barriers to investing:** The reasons given were fear of losing money, lack of knowledge, uncertainty about how to begin, business cash-flow needs and existing commitments to retirement funds. Lack of exposure and guidance was more common than unwillingness to invest.
- **Amounts and goals:** Respondents who were willing to start a SIP preferred amounts ranging from ₹100–₹500 for the SY student and ₹500–₹2,000 for the finance student to small, moderate or larger sums for others. Goals ranged from emergency savings and education to retirement security and long-term wealth creation, which supports goal-based planning.
- **Interest in learning:** All six respondents expressed interest in learning more about mutual funds and SIPs through awareness programmes.

These observations are drawn from a small sample and are indicative rather than representative. They nevertheless reflect the point made in Chapter 1: that greater industry growth and easier digital access have not yet closed the gap in investor understanding.

Chapter 5: Conclusion & Recommendation

Conclusion

This study assessed awareness of mutual funds and Systematic Investment Plans (SIPs) through structured interviews with six respondents from the college community: two students and four individuals from other backgrounds. Each respondent answered the same ten questions on awareness of mutual funds and SIPs, current investment habits, understanding of risk, reasons for not investing, a comfortable starting SIP amount, financial goals, belief about guaranteed returns and interest in awareness programmes, and was then briefed on the basics of mutual fund investing. Chapter 1 showed that the Indian mutual fund industry has grown rapidly, with assets under management reaching ₹85.76 trillion and 28.09 crore investor folios by July 2026. The interviews, however, showed that individual awareness remains uneven. Half of the respondents did not invest at all, half had only surface-level or very limited understanding of mutual funds and SIPs, and two believed SIPs give fixed returns while one was unsure. Even respondents who understood SIPs had reasons for not using them, such as business cash-flow needs or existing retirement commitments, which shows that guidance should be linked to each person's goals and circumstances. All six respondents expressed interest in learning more. This confirms that the core issue is not unwillingness to invest but a lack of prior exposure and simple, trustworthy guidance, which a structured awareness programme is well placed to provide. Because the sample is small and drawn from one college, the findings are indicative and cannot be generalised.

Recommendation

Given these findings, the primary recommendation is to build sustained financial literacy within the college community rather than treating an awareness camp as a one-time event. Sessions should explain mutual funds, SIPs, risk and return, and long-term goal-based planning in simple, jargon-free language, using relatable

examples and, where useful, local languages, and should clearly state that mutual fund returns are market-linked and not guaranteed. They should be conducted with the involvement of certified financial advisors or registered mutual fund distributors, and the institution could tie up with a small panel of trusted professionals who remain available periodically, so that students and staff can get guidance when they are ready to invest. Participants should be shown that SIPs suit regular savers, and that people with irregular cash flow, such as business owners, can consider other approaches with proper advice. Awareness of digital investing should include protecting personal and financial information and avoiding unregistered advisers and fraudulent schemes. Simple explainer material such as SIP-versus-lump-sum comparison charts and basic risk-return visuals should be distributed to reinforce what is taught. Finally, follow-up sessions or a feedback exercise a few months after the camp are recommended to check how many participants have started investing, address any hesitation, and keep financial literacy an ongoing effort within the college.

GUIDE INTERACTION DIARY FORM

(to be maintained by each student)

I, the undersigned Ms/ Mr. _____ Roll No. _____ studying in the _____ YEAR Of _____ Full time Course is doing my project work under the guidance of Dr./Ms./Mr. _____, wish to state that I have met my Internal guide on the following dates mentioned below for Project Guidance:-

Sr.No.	Date	Signature of the Internal Guide
1		
2		
3		
4		
5		
6		
7		
8		
9		
10		

Signature of the CandidateSignature of Internal Guide